

Military Reform, Civil-Military Relations, and Democratization

When a political system goes through changes, so too do its component parts, though not at the same pace or with the same impact. It is useful to visualize the democratic system as collection of interlocking subsystems, or what Philippe Schmitter referred to as partial regimes.¹ Those partial regimes might include political parties, electoral systems, political and civil liberties, mechanisms of accountability, and so on. They also include civil-military relations (CMR), and while linked to the other subsystems, CMR evolves according to its own internal rhythm and dynamic. It can lag behind other subsystems or it can outpace them. It also registers a distinct impact on the system writ large and on some of its components. The core of CMR lies within the defense sector, where the armed forces interact regularly with policymakers. But the military's influence can extend beyond that core, if and when soldiers affect the government's sovereign power to rule, restrict the selection of candidates and the entrance of political parties into the electoral arena, or curtail civil liberties in an effort to guard internal security.² If the military's influence over

¹ These partial regimes link up with others within the democracy, but they also have their own rules, institutions, internal logic, and patterns of development. Philippe C. Schmitter, "Civil Society East and West," in Larry Diamond, Marc Plattner, Y. H. Chu, and H. M. Tien (eds.), *Consolidating the Third Wave Democracies: Themes and Perspectives* (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1997), 239–62. Wolfgang Merkel has borrowed the concept and identified five partial regimes: electoral, political rights, civil rights, horizontal accountability, and effective power to rule. See his "Embedded and Defective Democracies," *Democratization*, 11, 5 (December 2004), 33–58.

² Aurel Croissant, David Kuehn, Phillip Lorenz, and Paul W. Chambers (eds.), *Democratization and Civilian Control in Asia* (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2013).

one or more of those partial regimes is serious enough, it can throw the democracy itself off course because the subsystems are interconnected.

For these reasons, the chapter begins with a depiction of democratic progress as it crosses thresholds and moves through phases of transition and consolidation. It then assesses in what manner the military could affect the system's trajectory at different points in that continuum. It could stall democratic gains or reverse them during the transitional periods, but if and when the democracy moves beyond transition, the military's threat dissipates, though it retains influence. It is then that civilians attempt to devise means of harnessing military strength and skill for the good of the nation while trying to consolidate and institutionalize their control over the military.

The chapter revisits some theories on civilian control of the armed forces and at the same time suggests that complex matters cannot be boiled down to just linear relations between political executives exerting control over military commanders. Instead it argues government-military interactions must be situated within the larger scope of civil-military interaction. That moves us toward a discussion of various dimensions that give us a window into what are triangular relations between soldiers, politicians, and civilians within society. Then, to know if relations are improving or not, a method has been devised to track progress along each dimension. Standards drawn from the civil-military field along with ordinal-ranked benchmarks will be clearly defined within each chapter so that we can assess how far countries have advanced along the journey to complete CMR reform.

The work of CMR reform does not occur at one point in time. It is phased in, with more pressing tasks taken up first while others are deferred; some occur during the transitional democratic phase, others during of the course of consolidation. Reforms are sequenced, and the logic of that sequencing will be discussed. Sequential progress in changing the CMR is connected to advances in democratization. In what is an iterative process, democratic leaders make the first moves to ensure viability for the new and fragile democracy before anyone attends to CMR transformations. Then preliminary CMR changes set the stage for further democratic gains, and those in turn open up the possibility for more advanced CMR reforms.

DEMOCRATIC PHASES AND THRESHOLDS

If there is a movement from authoritarian to democratic regimes – and that is not a given – then it is one that traverses through qualitatively

different phases. How these phases are identified, defined, and measured can vary and has been the subject of endless scholarly inquiry and debate.³ We've settled on more or less conventional terminology to delineate periods of authoritarian rule, transition, and consolidation. If the utility of any of these terms has been subjected to great scrutiny, it has been consolidation, owing to the fact that many so-called consolidated democracies have fallen far short of expectations, even though some have endured for decades. As O'Donnell quipped, there are polyarchies that have been in a state of "protracted unconsolidation" for some 20 years.⁴ Because it is acknowledged that many consolidated states have so much unfinished business to attend to, we've distinguished a period of consolidating from one of consolidation, the latter reflecting a higher order of accomplishment, marked not only by very substantial gains across all the vital procedural and substantive dimensions that comprise a quality democracy but also by a level of stability that makes systemic reversals practically unthinkable.

As can be seen in Figure 1.1, the road from authoritarianism to democracy features two systems, four periods, and two thresholds. During the early phase of the non-democratic stage, a *de facto* regime may be preparing its own controlled exit, forging deals with democratic opponents, or on the verge of collapse. Thus transitions can begin after periods of liberalization, pacting, or regime demise. Terms of transition are either imposed from above, negotiated, or dictated from below. With

³ Without intending to be exhaustive, we can highlight the following: Dankwart A. Rustow, "Transitions to Democracy," *Comparative Politics*, 2, 1 (1970): 337–63; Guillermo O'Donnell, Philippe Schmitter, and Larry Whitehead, *Transitions from Authoritarian Rule: Southern Europe* (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1986); O'Donnell and Schmitter, *Transitions from Authoritarian Rule: Tentative Conclusions about Uncertain Democracies* (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1986); the articles compiled in Geoffrey Pridham, *Transitions to Democracy. Comparative Perspectives from Southern Europe, Latin America and Eastern Europe* (London: Dartmouth Publishing Company Limited, 1995); Larry Diamond, Juan Linz, and Seymour Martin Lipset (eds.), *Politics in Developing Countries: Comparing Experiences with Democracy* (Boulder: Lynne Rienner Publishers, 1995); Yossi Shain and Juan J. Linz, *Between States: Interim Governments and Democratic Transitions* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1995); Juan Linz, and Alfred Stepan, *Problems of Democratic Transition and Consolidation. Southern Europe, South America and Post-Communist Europe* (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1996); Diamond et al. (eds.), *Consolidating the Third Wave Democracies*; Gerard Alexander, *The Sources of Democratic Consolidation* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 2002); Leonardo Morlino, *Democrazie e democratizzazioni* (Bologna: Il Mulino, 2003).

⁴ Guillermo O'Donnell, "Illusions about Consolidation," *Journal of Democracy*, 7 (April 1996), 38.

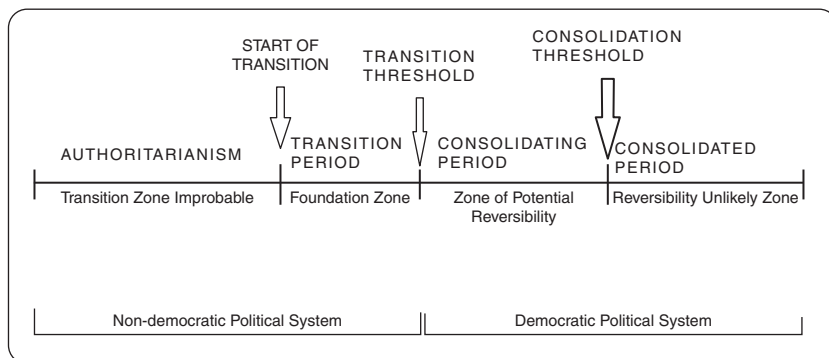


FIGURE 1.1 From Authoritarianism to a Democratic Consolidation
Source: Authors

presidential and legislative elections successfully completed, the system moves into a latter phase of transition we call foundational. Though the system is still ostensibly non-democratic, it is less so, as the polity slowly but surely acquires democratic traits. When the government in power has been freely elected, when it has the authority to make policies, and when the three branches of government “do not have to share power with other bodies de jure,” then the process is complete, according to Juan Linz and Alfred Stepan.⁵

Nothing is sure-footed about this process; it is an uncertain one, and there remains a high risk of regression toward authoritarian rule.⁶ Even if nations did not slide back to dictatorship, many once thought to be en route to democracy never got there, stalled or perhaps frozen in what Thomas Carouthers described as a gray zone.⁷ Others appeared to be on the verge of moving on, only to experience stunning reversals, as witnessed in Egypt. These trends do not render the transitional category meaningless but do quite strongly rebut the notion that there is something inevitable about the progression from transition to democracy.

Assuming a nation does make it through the transition, it crosses what is referred to as the first threshold, where an ostensibly non-democratic system becomes democratic. This is not to convey a real-world drama, where a nation awakens one fine morning to suddenly discover it is

⁵ Linz and Stepan, *Problems of Democratic Transition and Consolidation*, 3.

⁶ O'Donnell and Schmitter, *Transitions from Authoritarian Rule*.

⁷ Thomas Carouthers, “The End of the Transition Paradigm,” *Journal of Democracy*, 13 (January 2002), 5–21.

democratic. This is, as Andres Schedler put it, “an effort to divide a continuous scale into discrete parts.”⁸ It is an analytical device to convey the notion that there comes a point when an accumulation of incremental improvements reaches critical mass, earning the system the right of passage to a new, qualitatively different state.

Out of this emerges a period of consolidation in which successive legislative, structural, and cultural changes make the political system ever more democratic, though the risk of backsliding remains. Consolidation is still a period of flux (though more stable than transition) and should not convey a sense of steady state equilibrium. The difficulty is in the word: it is a noun, when it would be more useful to think of it as a verb. It is an act of becoming, of consolidating, where democratic processes are being solidified, institutions are strengthened, and norms are embraced.⁹ Hence, we’ve distinguished between a process of “consolidating” that directly succeeds the transitional period and a latter state that is “consolidated.”

If there are what might be termed any obligatory features to this consolidating process, they could be summed up by three “L’s”: loyalty, legitimacy, and legality.¹⁰ Loyalty is a condition where no significant social, political, or military actor devotes itself to the creation of an antidemocratic model or attempts a reversion to an authoritarian past. Legitimacy refers to the point where a large majority of public opinion believes that democratic procedures and institutions are the most appropriate for governing collective life. Lastly, legality refers to the fact that all actors have accustomed themselves to resolving conflicts by means of norms, procedures, and institutions that are sanctioned by the new democratic process. As Linz and Stepan have stated, these three advances have to be carried out within the civil, political, and economic arenas of democratic life: the *civil*, in order to exercise freedom of association and communication; the *political*, in order to control public power and the

⁸ Andres Schedler, “How Should We Study Democratic Consolidation?” *Democratization*, 5, 4 (Winter 1998), 9.

⁹ Larry Diamond, Francis Fukuyama, Donald L. Horowitz, and Marc F. Plattner, “Reconsidering the Transition Paradigm,” *Journal of Democracy*, 25, 1 (January 2014), 94.

¹⁰ See Rafael Martínez, “Objectives of Democratic Consolidation of the Armed Forces,” in David Mares and Rafael Martínez (eds.), *Debating Civil-Military Relations in Latin America* (Great Britain: Sussex Academic Press, 2014), 28; Linz and Stepan, in *Problems of Democratic Transition and Consolidation*, 6, hold that in order to achieve democratic consolidation, certain changes are required: behaviorally, attitudinally, and constitutionally.

state apparatus; and the *economic*, since it mediates between the state and the market.¹¹

Then a second Rubicon is crossed – where a consolidating system¹² enters a phase of consolidation fully realized, having all but escaped the danger of an authoritarian reversion. The three “L’s” have been fully realized, and the overall quality of the politically competitive system has been sufficiently deepened and eventually (hopefully) optimized.¹³ Though crises may develop, these are unlikely to result in regime decline or demise, so long as political institutions have become legitimate and anchored, firmly rooting themselves within society.¹⁴ The complete sequence of moves is depicted in Figure 1.1.

DEMOCRATIC PASSAGES AND THE MILITARY LINK

There are many ways in which a progression of this sort could be derailed. Politicians can rule so poorly for so long that they erode the public’s abiding faith not just in the current leadership but in democratic institutions themselves. Citizens may perceive that the institutions of state are failing them; that they are no longer representative, accountable, or transparent; and that those in power are abusing their authority. Perceptions of that sort could give way to feelings of frustration with the current regime and less aversion to an authoritarian alternative.

A government could implode under the weight of its own incompetence and malfeasance or, alternatively, could come under siege from disloyal elements determined to overthrow it on behalf of a disgruntled public. Of all those domestic agents who could profess disloyalty, the armed forces are the most formidable. They could, single-handedly, forestall further democratization by calling on their reserves of political power to threaten officeholders, block or veto undesired policies, and cling to positions and privileges that are not rightfully theirs.

¹¹ Linz and Stepan, *Problems of Democratic Transition and Consolidation*, 11.

¹² Larry Diamond justifies the use of “threshold” as a concept, saying: “If you can think about consolidation as the crossing of some threshold of stability, [and] of solidity.” Diamond et al., “Reconsidering the Transition Paradigm,” 94.

¹³ We hold the view, as did Robert Dahl, that democracy is an ideal that polyarchies strive for but seldom attain. Robert Dahl, *On Democracy* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1988).

¹⁴ Morlino, *Democrazie e democratizzazioni*, 116–30.

It should come as no surprise that in regions (e.g. Latin America) where countries emerged from military-dominated authoritarian regimes, the armed forces made their presence known after leaving office. They were often at the decision-making table when agreements were forged that set the terms of the transition.¹⁵ And well after the transition, they could still draw on their reserves of power, fighting tooth and nail to protect or enlarge their spheres of influence.¹⁶ The risk in the early going was that the military would greatly overstep its bounds, converting itself into a tutelary force, a self-bestowed guardian of a system that was democratic in name only. Or worse still, they would dispense with the democratic facade entirely and overturn the regime.

In sum the democratic period of transition and early consolidation was one characterized by the “military threat.” The difficulty is that no democracy can move through the consolidating process while shuddering under the military sword of Damocles. Indeed, the removal of this threat has been built into the very definition of democracy itself. Expanding on Robert Dahl’s classic polyarchy, Schmitter and Karl included the provision that elected officials must be able to govern without interference or overrides from military officers. Democracies are in jeopardy should they not fulfill this condition.¹⁷ Other scholars have since reaffirmed these and similar propositions.¹⁸

At least in Latin America, in the twenty-first century, the armed forces no longer wield the threat of coup d’état as convincingly as they had in the past. But it is also acknowledged that the absence of coups does not constitute a state of consolidation.¹⁹ As important as it is to remove the lingering threat of military coups, that is simply the first in a series of steps to restrict the military’s reach. When the coup threat has dissipated, armies have other means at their disposal to make their presence

¹⁵ Juan J. Linz and Alfred Stepan, “Relaciones civiles militares en recientes transiciones democráticas del Cono Sur de América Latina,” *Síntesis: Revista Documental de Ciencias Sociales*, 11 (1994), 77–85.

¹⁶ J. S. Valenzuela, “Democratic Consolidation in Post-Transitional Settings: Notion, Process, and Facilitating Conditions,” Working Paper, 150 Helen Kellogg Institute for International Studies, University of Notre Dame, 1990.

¹⁷ Philippe C. Schmitter and Terry L. Karl, “What Democracy Is . . . And Is Not,” *Journal of Democracy*, 2 (Summer 1991), 75–88.

¹⁸ Michael Desch says that “the bottom line for developed democracies is civilian control.” *Civilian Control of the Military: The Changing Security Environment* (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1999), 4.

¹⁹ Aurel Croissant, David Kuehn, Paul Chambers, and Siegfried O. Wolf, “Beyond the Fallacy of Coup-ism: Conceptualizing Civilian Control of the Military in Emerging Democracies,” *Democratization*, 17, 5 (2010), 950–75.

felt: vetoing undesired policies, voicing public objections to decisions, and shirking responsibilities as a bargaining chip to pry concessions out of political leaders, to name a few. In short, at this stage, the military's subordination is what J. Samuel Fitch describes as conditional in nature.²⁰ Absent effective measures to deprive the military of these forms of influence, no democracy can consolidate.

The challenge however does not end once democracies are free from harmful military influences. Governments need some means of converting armies from "the bad guys to the good guys." Nations rely on their militaries for a multitude of tasks. They call on soldiers to fight, to keep the peace, to build infrastructure, and to rescue those in peril in the face of natural disasters. Government officials, no matter how able, still depend on their commanders for sage advice, particularly on matters of external defense. Militaries cannot ably serve political elites if they are bent on obstruction or intimidation. But neither can they serve as useful advisors if they are ignored or rendered obsequious. Hence, a democracy has to walk the line between encouraging military communications while avoiding military domination. It must convert what was once a menacing force into a reliable policy instrument and partner. Many scholars are convinced that the solution is to devise improved methods of democratic civilian control.

DEMOCRATIC CIVILIAN CONTROL AND THE MILITARY CONVERSION

In order to consolidate a democracy, the military institution must be transformed. Narcis Serra puts it plainly: "... military reform is no more than a process of driving and guiding the military to shift gradually to positions of greater democratic normalcy and to fit coherently into the new democratic state."²¹ Others may agree and yet not reach any consensus about what the necessary ingredients are for that change nor how to implement them. Zoltan Barany has argued that because settings are different, there is no "one size fits all" method for transforming the armed forces, nor are lessons learned in one context easily transferrable elsewhere.²²

²⁰ J. Samuel Fitch, *The Armed Forces and Democracy in Latin America* (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1998), 6.

²¹ Serra, *The Military Transition*, 43–44.

²² Zoltan Barany, *The Soldier and the Changing State: Building Democratic Armies in Africa, Asia, Europe and the America* (Princeton, Princeton University Press, 2012).

While scholars can and do debate the means to get there, they generally agree on the goal: military neutrality and subordination within a democratic state. Armies must not take political sides or make political decisions while at the same time obeying the legitimate elected authorities and complying with the new juridical order. The goal is to have militaries that are fully supportive of democratic rule. As Barany states:

Democracy cannot be consolidated without military elites committed to democratic rule and obedient to democratically elected political elites. Good militaries are a necessary, if insufficient condition of democratization.²³

Military unconditional submission to the authority of elected officials has been the *sine qua non* of a democratically compatible CMR.²⁴ As simple a condition as this may be, it presents a conundrum since, as Michael Desch holds: “Military institutions are inherently undemocratic, because they are hierarchically organized.”²⁵ How then does a nation get an authoritarian institution to be a democratically abiding one?

The short answer is civilian control: devising a system that assures that this non-democratic entity falls into line with the decisions made by its executive overseers, whether it wants to or not and whether it agrees with policies or not.²⁶ The armed forces wield enormous coercive power, and it is that power that must be channeled to achieve the goals set out by governments. The challenge is to build a military coercively strong enough to provide for the common defense and yet compliant enough to harness its power only as and when directed by the democratic authorities.²⁷ Therefore, as Peter Feaver put it, the twin goals are “to have protection *by* the military and to have protection *from* the military.”²⁸ This is true to the point that we could plausibly

²³ Ibid., 3.

²⁴ Samuel P. Huntington, *The Soldier and the State: The Theory and Politics of Civil-Military Relations* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1957); Janowitz, *The Professional Soldier*; Felipe Agüero, *Militares, civiles y democracia: La España posfranquista en perspectiva comparada* (Madrid: Alianza, 1995).

²⁵ Desch, *Civilian Control of the Military*, 5.

²⁶ Peter D. Feaver, “Civil-Military Relations,” *Annual Review of Political Science*, 2 (1999), 211–41.

²⁷ It is not a natural condition for militaries to obey civilians; it is a condition that must be constructed. In the course of history, countless men in uniform have chosen instead to turn against their own governments, and more often than not, heads of state have been powerless to stop them.

²⁸ Peter Feaver, *Armed Servants: Agency, Oversight, and Civil-Military Relations* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2003), 6.

affirm that without civilian control, there is no democracy,²⁹ though obviously many other democratic-enhancing conditions must be in place as well. Put more precisely, civilian control is a necessary condition for the consolidation of a democracy but an insufficient one. “Civilian dominance does not *assure* the consolidation of democracy,” as David Mares has argued³⁰ (emphasis ours).

The difficulty with the term *civilian control* is that it does not discriminate between democratic and non-democratic systems. Authoritarian executives in Russia, China, and the Mid-East have successfully subordinated their armed forces but certainly not in ways consistent with democratic rule. Consequently, the concept of democratic civilian control is preferred to connote that while executive supremacy over the armed forces is critical, it is too narrow and incomplete. The armed forces are also obligated to conform to legislative outcomes, and more broadly to the laws and norms befitting a democratic regime and society.³¹

There are many definitions of democratic civilian control, and this is not the place to contemplate them all. Essentially, control itself has to do with civilians “enjoying uncontested decision-making powers” in areas that are critical to the survival and success of a functioning democracy.³² Not all policy arenas are of equal importance, and as David Pion-Berlin, Harold Trinkunas, and Aurel Croissant et al. have emphasized, the closer those arenas are to core functions of a democratic regime – be that the selection of leaders, legislating, or the making of policies outside of defense – then the more imperative it is that civilians have sole discretion.³³ Any effort by officers to either claim or contest authority in those arenas constitutes a direct threat to democratic rule. However, the further removed one is from that core, then the more permissible it is to

²⁹ David Kuehn, “Democratization and Civilian Control of the Military in Taiwan,” *Democratization*, 15, 5 (2008), 870–90.

³⁰ Mares, *Civil-Military Relations*, 246. For Mares, control is neither a sufficient nor a necessary condition. We respectfully disagree on that point.

³¹ Fitch, *The Armed Forces and Democracy*, 34–36; Cottey, Edmunds, and Forster, “The Second Generation Problematic,” 31–56.

³² Croissant et al. (eds.), *Democratization and Civilian Control in Asia*, 26.

³³ David Pion-Berlin, “Military Autonomy and Emerging Democracies in South America,” *Comparative Politics*, 25 (October 1992), 83–102; Harold Trinkunas, *Crafting Civilian Control of the Military in Venezuela: A Comparative Perspective* (Chapel Hill, NC: University of North Carolina Press, 2005); Croissant et al. (eds.), *Democratization and Civilian Control in Asia*.

contemplate areas of shared civil-military authority or, in the case of internal organization, prescribed areas of military autonomy.³⁴

Disagreements surface regarding what drives the armed forces to ultimately agree to these restricted spheres of influence. Those disputes are informed by different theoretical preferences that tend to converge around a few main analytical poles. For rationalists, military behavior is driven by self-interest.³⁵ The armed forces could cooperate because they either stand to gain materially from good behavior or stand to lose by shirking their duties and being caught. So rationalists tend to focus either on the military's corporate interests that motivate or restrain non-cooperation³⁶ or on the civilian side, where they look at the mix of reward and punishment strategies at the disposal of state decision-makers.

Structuralists analyze large impersonal forces that could influence the chances for civilian control.³⁷ Among those forces are the regional security environment, economic systems, or the structure of social classes. Structures tend to be unwavering, only occasionally subject to change, and also several steps removed from policymakers themselves. Hence they act more like parameters, and intervening variables that link structure with decision-makers would have to be identified.

Institutionalists put their stock in organizational designs that can either define barriers to entry for soldiers who would attempt to unduly influence policy or conversely ease the soldier's access to the centers of power.³⁸ Military behavior would be subject to rules and procedures

³⁴ A. R. Luckham, "A Comparative Typology of Civil-Military Relations," *Government & Opposition*, 6, 1 (1971), 5–35, developed a typology according to the strength of the civilian and military institutions as well as the nature of the frontiers (integral, permeable, or fragmented) dividing those two worlds. Anton Bebler alluded to an imaginary axis whose theoretical extremes were *civilocracy* and *milocracy*. Anton Bebler, "Typologies Based on Civilian-Dominated versus Military-Dominated Political Systems," in Anton Bebler and Jim Seroka (eds.) *Contemporary Political Systems. Classifications and Typologies* (Boulder: Lynne Rienner Publishers, Inc., 1990); David Mares refers to four configurations: civilian dominant, military dominant, a pact among equals, and parallel spheres-of-action. See his *Civil-Military Relations*.

³⁵ Wendy Hunter, *Eroding Military Influence in Brazil: Politicians against Soldiers* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1997); Peter Feaver, *Armed Servants: Agency, Oversight, and Civil-Military Relations* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2003).

³⁶ Eric Nordlinger, *Soldiers in Politics: Military Coups and Governments* (Englewood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice-Hall, 1977).

³⁷ Desch, *Civilian Control of the Military*.

³⁸ Deborah Avant, *Political Institutions and Military Change: Lessons from Peripheral Wars* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1994); David Pion-Berlin, *Through*

embedded within an institutional setting. Not surprisingly, these scholars contemplate how key defense-related organizations (e.g. the defense ministry) could be reconfigured to increase a policymaker's autonomy and capacity. Finally, culturalists contend that what citizens, soldiers, and rulers believe is of utmost importance.³⁹ They look at the wider political culture and the narrower subcultures of military organizations and how these influence civilian and military attitudes, perceptions, and beliefs. Huntington's own theory of objective control – which belongs within this genre – rests on the premise that political subordination can derive from a strong professional ethos.

In short, military subordination would be rooted in either interests, structures, institutions, or beliefs, depending on which analytical path is chosen. If any one of these bases was both necessary and sufficient for civilian control, there would be no need for discussion of a more integrative, analytical approach. But none are, and these partial visions lead scholars to focus a particular feature of CMR at the expense of others. As a result of pursuing these distinct intellectual paths, scholars diverge in their assessments, descriptions, and measures of CMR. And so it should come as no surprise that they also have failed to produce a widely accepted theory of CMR and its role in the process of political change.⁴⁰ This book will not claim to have developed such a theory, but it will offer a systematic means to conceptualize and operationalize CMR that encompasses multiple views.

REFORMING THE MILITARY BY REFORMING CMR

The ultimate goal for a democracy is to irreversibly transform the armed forces into an administrative instrument of the state. Devoid of any political intent or ambition of their own, they serve the government by converting defense decisions into operational tasks and serve the nation as a whole by defending it against threats to its sovereignty and democratic way of life. Insofar as they are public functionaries, armed forces personnel must be objective and professional. Objectivity requires a neutral

Corridors of Power: Institutions and Civil-Military Relations in Argentina (University Park, PA: Penn State University Press, 1997).

³⁹ S. E. Finer, *The Man on Horseback: The Role of the Military in Politics* (Westview Press, 1988); Fitch, *The Armed Forces and Democracy*; Brian Taylor, *Politics and the Russian Army: Civil-Military Relations, 1689–2000* (Cambridge University Press, 2003).

⁴⁰ Desch, *Civilian Control*, 3, 98.

attitude: the capacity to work under any elected government, no matter its political coloration, without qualms, prejudices, or preconceived notions. Just as any citizen, a military official can and should have political ideas. What he cannot have is the right to express those ideas publicly and the ambition to impose, individually or collectively, those ideas on the political decision-makers. It follows that he cannot openly affiliate with political parties nor link up with social groups that may want to exploit their connections to further their own agendas. Any such affiliations introduce biases that should be avoided. In short, objectivity allows the military to achieve a comfort level with being a tool of power and not a power itself.

As a professional, the military officer is a *specialist*, offering up his skills to the service of his government and nation. His skills are honed within an institution that puts a premium on hierarchy, discipline, and obedience to command. Without these features, no army could fulfill its mandate to defend the borders and fight wars if need be. While he dedicates himself only to the military craft, his professionalism does not drive his political neutrality. That only arises through a transformative process tied to various civilian initiatives, institutions, and educational reforms within the academy. His professionalism however does give him considerable knowledge about defense affairs that could be put to good use. Thus on occasion, and only as required, he may collaborate with civilians in the making of decisions.

And finally he is also a *citizen* who, like all citizens, has rights, freedoms, and duties, though certain limitations will be placed on the free range of his liberties in deference to the unique tasks he must fulfill.⁴¹ Thus he has a responsibility to his political overseers but also a responsibility to the society from whence he came. He and his fellow soldiers must deliver the public good known as defense to the society as a whole. And they must do so without taking sides or upending democratic practices, values, and the rule of law. In sum, the democratic consolidation of the armed forces is their conversion into an administrative instrument at the service of their elected government and their fellow citizens.

The issue is how do we get there? What is the process by which a country transforms the military from a formidable power broker

⁴¹ Rafael Martínez, "Las reales ordenanzas ¿Una norma inconstitucional?" in Fernando López Ramón (ed.), *La función militar* (Zaragoza: Ed. Trotta, Academia General Militar and Fundación Lucas Mallada, 1995); Rafael Martínez, *Los mandos de las fuerzas armadas españolas del siglo XXI* (Madrid: CIS, 2007).

into a compliant instrument of a democratic state? As vital as democratic civilian control is to the CMR and to the democracy, it cannot be thought of as a synecdoche, the representation of a relation that is considerably broader and more complex. Any identification of CMR with control itself is an ill-advised exercise in reductionism.⁴² Who is guarding the guardians and how cannot be the only query of interest to those concerned about CMR, and for good reason. How well governments can manage, interact with, and subordinate the military to the needs of a democratic state hinges on broader elements of the civil-military complex itself.

The need to widen the scope of inquiry led Thomas Bruneau and Florina Cristiana Matei to argue for a trinity of control, effectiveness, and efficiency.⁴³ Even if militaries do fully comply with governmental decisions, it must be asked, how well do they execute those decisions? Are they conducting missions in a manner that will achieve the desired outcomes? And are they doing so at a manageable cost to the nation? The whole issue of military effectiveness and efficiency has to be broached.

That method, however useful, does not go far enough. Analysts should take a step or two back and ask how desirable missions are derived in the first place. Effectiveness is always assessed in relation to objectives, and thus ultimately whether the military is being put to good use is a question that can only be evaluated in relation to the nation's priorities. It is the voting public that judges its government's performance, and defense policy is one element by which it renders such judgments. What do citizens want of their military? Do they want a large war-fighting force that consumes a huge portion of the federal budget? Do they believe such resources should be spent on foreign military ventures, be it peacekeeping or fighting terrorism, or would they be better spent at home on non-military-related problems? And those questions press up against two more fundamental ones: How much does the public care or even know about defense? And what value does it place on its military to begin with?

⁴² Those who agree include Yagil Levy, "A Revised Model of Civilian Control of the Military: The Interaction between the Republican Exchange and the Control Exchange," *Armed Forces & Society*, 38, 4 (2012), 529–56; José A. Olmeda, "Escape from Huntington's Labyrinth: Civil-Military Relations and Comparative Politics," in Thomas C. Bruneau and Florina Cristiana Matei (eds.), *The Routledge Handbook of Civil-Military Relations* (New York: Routledge, 2013), 61–76.

⁴³ Thomas C. Bruneau and Florina Cristiana Matei (eds.), *The Routledge Handbook of Civil-Military Relations* (New York: Routledge, 2013), 26–38.

Answering those questions should steer researchers in two directions: looking at citizen understandings of and relations with their armed forces and, secondly, examining the extent to which the electorate incentivizes politicians to focus their attention sufficiently on military affairs. The two phenomena are related. A public that holds the military in low regard or that is simply disinterested and ill-informed may be one unwilling to prompt its representatives to invest their time and energy into properly managing the military. A vacuum results that could invite self-management on the part of the officer corps. As Janowitz warned decades ago:

Unanticipated militarism develops...from a failure of civilian leaders to act relevantly and consistently. Under such circumstances, a vacuum is created which not only encourages an extension of the power of military leadership, but actually compels such trends.⁴⁴

In short, this discussion points to ways in which effective government control over its military hinges on elements well beyond it, strongly suggesting the need to broaden the scope of inquiry. We are reminded of Huntington's advice long ago that the CMR "... should be studied as a system composed of interdependent elements," which interact with one another, and where "... no one of these elements can change without producing further changes in the other elements."⁴⁵ Later on, Fitch reinforced the message, stating that effective military policy is that which deals with the "relationships between the armed forces, the state, and the rest of society" and not just control.⁴⁶ He adds, "A military policy for democratic consolidation takes as its ultimate objective the creation of a system of civil-military relations insuring democratic control of the armed forces."⁴⁷ Barany echoed these reflections in a recent volume: "In modern democracies military politics should be understood as a set of relationships between a set of institutions. The institutions belong to one of three sides of the civil-military relations triangle: state, society, or the military itself."⁴⁸

⁴⁴ Janowitz, *The Professional Soldier*, 14.

⁴⁵ Huntington, *The Soldier and the State*, viii. In their book rendering homage to Huntington, upon the 50th anniversary of the publication of *The Soldier and the State*, the editors, Suzanne C. Nielsen and Don M. Snider, allude to this issue as well, noting that there are five sets of interdependent relations. See Suzanne C. Nielsen and Don M. Snider (eds.), *American Civil-Military Relations: The Soldier and the State in a New Era* (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 2009), 2–4.

⁴⁶ Fitch, *The Armed Forces and Democracy*, 134. ⁴⁷ Ibid., 135.

⁴⁸ Barany, *The Soldier and the Changing State*, 25.

These insights move us beyond just executive management of military affairs and the linear interactions between civilian defense officials and the high command. In fact, they move us beyond government entirely, to consider an array of facets that constitute a civil-military system and its three main protagonists. Christopher Dandeker argues there are two main interactions between the three key actors: (1) the armed forces and their society, marking the areas of convergence or divergence and the tensions between both; and (2) the armed forces and government where the control of coercive force is resolved along with the determination of missions and the levels of professional autonomy.⁴⁹

Getting military reform right means getting CMR right. It means being able to answer the three-fold question: what do CMR look like, how do they improve, and how would we know when they have? At this stage, the exercise is *not* a causal one; it is a conceptual and descriptive one. As a system, CMR is too large and unwieldy to be reduced to a few independent explanatory variables. What we are searching for is a more comprehensive and accurate *characterization* of the system, one that will allow us to identify its multiple dimensions. Once those dimensions are known and measured, then the CMR as an aggregate can be better understood.

REFORMING THE CMR: A HOLISTIC FRAMEWORK WITH SIX DIMENSIONS

The proposed framework is composed of a bundle of relations called dimensions. Each dimension (six in all) pertains to a different yet related facet of CMR, and each is designed to track advances over time. These dimensions touch on issues that are central to CMR: power, law, institutions, knowledge, values, and performance. Each of these concepts alone would be an important entrée into the civil-military world. But any singular attention to any one of these concepts would yield partial

⁴⁹ Christopher Dandeker, "The Military in Democratic Societies: New Times and New Patterns of Civil-Military Relations," in Jürgen Kuhlmann and Jean Callaghan (eds.), *Military and Society in 21st Century in Europe: A Comparative Analysis* (New Brunswick: Transaction Publishers & Lit Verlag, 2000); In *The Military and Domestic Politics: A Concordance Theory of Civil-Military Relations* (New York: Routledge, 2009), Rebecca Schiff suggests a theory of civil-military concordance, an "agreement among the military, the political elites and the citizenry, found in a wide range of cultures where there has long been substantial agreement among all sectors of society about the role of armed forces," 47.

visions of the CMR, inescapably leading to questions about what was left out. If CMR are to be visualized as an interconnected whole as noted scholars have advised, it makes sense to broaden the perspective by investigating all six of these dimensions and relations between them.

The first dimension is called “Military Power.” Power is at the very center of any discussion on granting civilian leaders greater discretion. As Huntington put it, “Consequently, the basic problem in defining civilian control is: How can military power be minimized?”⁵⁰ Political leaders and policymakers must be free from military interference. Their autonomy is enhanced by altering the balance of power in their favor, ensuring that the armed forces cannot meddle in spheres that do not pertain to them. This means reducing the military’s own autonomy – its claims to rightful domination over an issue – and restricting its decision-making latitude – its ability to reach across issue areas well beyond its core interests.

Power struggles play out in several key arenas. For example, militaries should be denied any role in the selection of leaders or the formation of public policies outside of defense. In the judicial arena, soldiers – who are citizens and subject to the laws of the land like everyone else – should be prosecuted in civilian tribunals, while military court jurisdictions should be circumscribed. Under dictatorial rule, it was common to see soldiers patrolling city streets, as the armed forces dominated all domestic security functions. In a democracy that would be unwise. Civilian democrats must organize the internal security arena as they see fit, resorting to military use only on the rarest of occasions. And finally, as well informed as officers may be on defense, they cannot set the agenda. Control over defense policy must reside in the hands of elected officials and their appointees, while officers are confined to advisory roles within the state.

The struggle for power and its resolution is often captured in the laws that democracies devise. In fact, law is in a real sense the embodiment of previous political struggles now codified into rules that players are obligated to follow. Any reform of CMR must be grounded in law so that what had been fought over or negotiated is rendered more permanent. Whether or not laws are actually adhered to continues to be an open question; the civil-military road has for too long been paved with good statutes that have been broken. But the normative challenge is to set

⁵⁰ Huntington, *The Soldier and the State*, 80.

standards against which CMR can be evaluated, and in our view, a proper legal foundation is fundamental to success.

Thus, the second dimension is labeled “A Legal Framework” and encompasses the key laws that help define the powers and responsibilities of those within the civil-military system. It begins at the top with the constitution that often defines who the armed forces are, the limits to their powers, and their principal missions as well as the exceptional missions permitted under constitutional states of exception. It also defines the chain of command beginning with the president and delineates the division of labor between the congress and executive branch when it comes to military issues. The framework also includes the security and defense laws that differentiate between external and internal threat environments and how military and police roles differ. Then there are statutes that regulate the internal organization of the armed forces (retirement and promotion, training, logistics, doctrine, rules of conduct, management) and others that define military and civilian court jurisdictions.

Power struggles, followed by legal enactments can set a foundation for the reform of CMR but do not go far enough. These gains must be translated into institutions so that civil-military interactions, *in practice*, follow operational rules and procedures that engender greater government control but also informed military input. Institutions are the vehicles with which power balances and law can be translated into preferred, stable patterns of conduct and have been the subject of many civil-military studies.⁵¹ This dimension, called “Defense Institutions,” refers to a set of organizations (defense ministries, joint military staffs, national defense/security councils, and congress and its commissions) within which security, defense, and military policies are debated, crafted, and implemented. Decision, coordination, collaboration, and execution are the words that embody the practical daily work of these entities. It is at these sites where government and military officials often interface to exchange views. Though officers (and politicians)

⁵¹ For a sample, see Martin Edmonds, *Central Organizations of Defense* (Boulder, CO: Westview, 1985); Thomas C. Bruneau and Richard B. Goetze, Jr., “Ministries of Defense and Democratic Control,” in Thomas C. Bruneau and Scott D. Tollefson (eds.), *Who Guards the Guardians and How: Democratic Civil-Military Relations* (Austin: University of Texas Press, 2006); David Pion-Berlin, “Defense Organizations and Civil-Military Relations in Latin America,” *Armed Forces & Society*, 35, 3 (April 2009), 562–86.

have been known to pursue unofficial avenues of influence,⁵² militaries increasingly understand that it is to their advantage to work within official channels so they can earn some measure of respect for conforming to the democratic rules of the game. Accordingly, defense institutions exert considerable influence over the ebb and flow of political power, and especially who gets to sit at the decision-making table and who is left out. They are central to any investigation of CMR.

Institutions shape patterns of conduct, but it is people who make policy. Defense organizations in the executive and legislative branches need to be staffed by individuals who are sufficiently well informed to be able to craft wise policies while holding their own with able military advisors. The capacity of a minister to command authority and respect from senior officers rests, in part, on his ability to demonstrate some defense wisdom. In the next dimension, “Knowledge,” we analyze what it takes to develop career tracks so that civilians can receive proper training within the academies that prepares them and routes them into government service. Latin American scholars are in wide agreement that civilian ministers (and their staffs) are not sufficiently well versed on national security and defense affairs. Because civilians have not been up to the task, they defer to military judgments, which just reinforces the conviction that officers should be left alone to make defense policies. Arguably, few deficits have so preoccupied civil-military scholars and practitioners as this one, and addressing it is thus another vital component to completing the CMR profile.

At the same time, while soldiers have long received solid defense educations, that has occurred in remarkably insular settings. This has deprived them of exposure to civilian thinking and points of view that could sensitize them to the need to tailor defense and security thinking to the requisites of a democratic nation. Overcoming this problem may require the political leadership to oversee a revamping of the military educational experience, fostering a greater interconnection with civilian universities, professors, and students.⁵³

The next dimension on “Convergence” deals with breaking down barriers that separate the military from the larger society. Civil society

⁵² See David Pion-Berlin, “Informal Civil-Military Relations in Latin America: Why Politicians and Soldiers Choose Unofficial Venues,” *Armed Forces & Society*, 36, 3 (2010), 526–44.

⁵³ Alfred Stepan, *Rethinking Military Politics: Brazil and the Southern Cone* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1988).

has to pay greater heed to the military's unique contributions to national well-being. The military in turn should adapt to society's values and aspirations. But convergence is not just a meeting of the minds; it must be consistent with democratic standards. Civilians must adopt views of the military that are compatible with a maturing democracy. The armed forces meanwhile need to be disabused of the notion that they are somehow superior to politicians and civilians alike. This is a dangerous belief that can lead the armed forces down the slippery slope to presuming they know best for the democracy, its national interests, and the means to defend them. Thus convergence also means getting the military to see itself less as an elite, corporate entity separate from the democratic state and society and more as an integral part of it.

As Moskos, Serra, and others who have followed in the Janowitz tradition have argued, this change in mind-set would be facilitated to the extent that the armed forces embraced an occupational model of its profession. That would occur where soldiers saw the commonalities between themselves and non-uniformed employees, where military life was visualized less as a heroic mission and more as a professional choice akin to others within society, subject to laws, trends, and market-driven forces.⁵⁴ Breaking down barriers also means opening up recruitment so that it taps into a diverse demographic while reducing the tendency to create an inbred class of cadets drawn primarily from military families.

Finally, a key component of CMR improvement is to get better results. Is the military reconfigured and resized to be an effective fighting force rather than an occupational force inside its own nation? Are missions undertaken those that are consistent with a democratic state, and do they comport with foreign policy objectives? When policymakers produce better results, then at least in theory, this should redound to the benefit of government, which accrues greater credibility in the eyes of its citizens. The final dimension, "Effectiveness," deals with these issues. To be more effective in the realm of defense and security also means to be more strategic, to align resources, means, and objectives. Strategic choices should be made by governments because only they – not the armed forces – can calibrate security and defense priorities with a society's competing

⁵⁴ Charles Moskos and Frank R. Wood, *The Military: More Than Just a Job?* (New York: Elmsford Park, Pergamon-Brassey's, 1987); Omar Gutiérrez Valdebenito, *Sociología militar. La profesión militar en la sociedad democrática* (Santiago de Chile, Editorial Universitaria S.A.), 2002.

TABLE 1.1 *Civil-Military Relations, Dimensions, and Components*

Dimension	Component	Subcomponent
1. Military Power	Public Policymakers and Policy	Leadership Selection Policy Selection Public Defense Enterprises
	Human Rights Internal Security	Military Role Military-Police Relations
2. Legal Framework	External Defense	
	Constitutional Law Laws on Security and Defense Organizational Military Laws Military Justice Law Legal States of Exception	
3. Defense Institutions	Defense Ministry	
	Security/Defense Council Joint Military Staff Parliamentary Commissions	
4. Knowledge	Civilian Expertise Military Education	
5. Convergence	Societal Views of Military	
	Move toward Occupational Model Nontraditional Recruitments End Discriminatory Comforts	
6. Effectiveness	Strategy and Assessment	
	Transparency and Accountability Missions Optimize Expenditures Optimize Military Size Move from Conscripted to Volunteer Military	

Source: Authors.

needs. Performance has to be assessed as well, which means making decisions more transparent and devising a system of accountability.

The full array of dimensions and their components are summarized in Table 1.1.

It should first be evident that these dimensions do help us get at a myriad of civil-military qualities that traverse state-societal boundaries, as shown in Figure 1.2. Three of the dimensions are situated within the state realm, one is societal in nature, and the other two lie at the intersection between state and society. For instance, it falls primarily upon the political elites within the state to reduce the military's prerogatives and

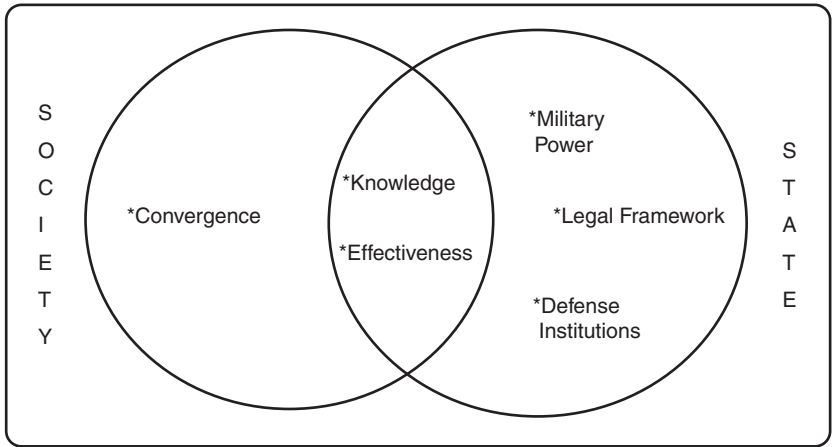


FIGURE 1.2 Dimensions and State-Societal Boundaries
Source: Authors

autonomy while enhancing their own. The power component addresses the struggle between executive and judicial officials at one end with senior military officers at the other end. The legal framework is designed by parliamentarians in collaboration with the president, and so here too the work is situated within the state. Defense institutions are those within the executive and legislative branches of government. At the societal end, convergence occurs when there is a greater symmetry between civilian and soldier views, ones that are democratically compatible. The military officer adapts his views and shifts his practices increasingly to those embraced by society and becomes in Janowitz's view a citizen-soldier. The objective is to bring the military into step with the civilian mainstream ideologically and occupationally. Soldiers identify themselves with non-uniformed employees in other vocations and can more easily transfer their skills to other jobs within the private sector.

At the intersection of state and society lies knowledge generation and effectiveness. The first has to do with creating a cadre of civilians qualified to staff state-centered defense agencies in the executive and legislative branches. This requires building programs that bridge educational institutions, research centers, and NGOs within society to ministries, defense councils, and commissions within the state. The second relates to a fundamental role of a democratic state, which is to demonstrate to the satisfaction of its citizens that it can govern effectively. Defense and security policies are not excluded from this obligation. To the extent that policies in this arena that are initiated by state officials are judged

TABLE 1.2 *A Hypothetical Dimension and Components*

Dimension	Component	None	Little	Moderate	Substantial
	1				
	2				
	3				
	4				
Transition	Consolidating	Consolidated			

to be effective by members of society, then the democratic government and by extension the democratic state itself accrue greater legitimacy.

As shown in Table 1.1, the six dimensions are disaggregated into 25 components and five subcomponents in all, and progress is tracked and assessed for each of these. The question remains how do we know progress when we see it? Any normative study has to identify goals and design standards and measures for goal achievement. This study does just that for each of the dimensions and its component parts. Ordinal-ranked benchmarks for success (none, little, moderate, and substantial) will be clearly defined within each chapter so that we can assess how far policy-makers have advanced along the journey to complete CMR reform for each dimension.

Overlaying that assessment is a second one. We want to situate these incremental gains within the context of movements from one CMR phase to another. This gives us a clearer sense of how well CMR is advancing with respect to the larger political system and its evolution from authoritarian to full-fledged democratic rule. As mentioned previously, the civil-military relation is one component of that larger democratic system, and just as the democracy as a whole moves through phases, so too does the CMR, as shown in Tables 1.2 and 1.3. Like the democracy, it advances through periods of transition and two phases of consolidation, though these do not converge temporally with those of the larger democratic system. Where the cutoff points are between CMR-democratic transitions, consolidating states, and full consolidation vary from dimension to dimension, as subsequent chapters will indicate in table form.

Benchmarks for each dimension do not map onto the three phases in precisely the same way. For some dimensions, smaller steps will suffice to achieve threshold-like changes; other dimensions will require giant leaps. Thus there will likely be easier transformations across the thresholds for

TABLE 1.3 *Intensity of Dimensional Activities by CMR-Democratic Phases*

Dimension	Democratization		
	Transition	Consolidating	Consolidated
Military Power			
Legal Framework			
Defense Institutions			
Knowledge			
Convergence			
Effectiveness			

Level of intensity: 1–5

High	4	3	2	Low

some dimensions than others. For purposes of illustration, a hypothetical dimension is presented in Table 1.2, with the three phased transitions overlaying the ordinal measures of progress. The transformation of the first component is more difficult than for the others. Moderate progress still does not get the country beyond the state of transition, substantial advances realize a consolidating state, but full consolidation is an unattainable prospect. By contrast component 3 is the easiest hill to climb, since policymakers can achieve a small dose of progress and with that shift into a consolidating phase, while moderate changes are enough to arrive at a state of full consolidation.

After analyses are done for all the components to a dimension, final country evaluations will be made at the end of each chapter. We will be able to answer the questions, for a given dimension and component: how has a country progressed, and how do its gains compare with those of other nations?

THE SEQUENCING OF CMR REFORMS

CMR dimensions and components (Table 1.1) do not all develop at the same rhythm, the result being that some emerge more prominently in earlier phases of democratization and others in later phases. As shown in Table 1.3, the intensity with which political leaders direct their energies toward reforming aspects of CMR will vary from one time period to the next. Why would this be so?

During earlier periods of democratization, roughly contiguous with transition, the essential reforms have to center on reducing military power and devising new laws. Civilians must, through some mix of carrots and sticks, persuade the military to relinquish power, content itself with diminished prerogatives, not interfere with the election and selection of leaders, and at least conditionally resign itself to civilian supremacy. And some basic legal changes have to be implemented so that there is a statutory consensus on what rules of the game will be.

Without this foundation two problems would surface. The first is that the further transformation of CMR would be stalled, since other advances depend on these first two. For example, if the military still has enough political muscle to interfere in the work of the defense minister, it is hard to see how the defense ministry itself could ever come into its own as an effective policy-promoting institution (see dimension 3). And if laws are not passed to place the defense ministry in the operational chain of command, just below the president, then officers are not legally prohibited from communicating directly with the president, bypassing the defense minister entirely. If that occurs, it matters little how well staffed the ministry is with competent civilian personnel (dimension 4). Powerful generals will disregard the ministry, treating it as an empty shell.

Secondly, without first-phase CMR reforms of the sort mentioned, then democratic progress itself will suffer. Should the armed forces have sufficient political power to interfere with the selection of leaders, and public polices outside of defense, then it is impinging on a key component of democracy, the ability to rule. Effective governance is a particularly important partial regime and if made vulnerable could prove to be democracy's Achilles' heel, dragging the entire edifice down with it. If, for instance, the military could veto cabinet appointments or economic, labor, or foreign policy choices, then the system will have lost governing sovereignty, which is a vital condition for any democracy.

Hence in the earlier phase, it is important that civilians alter the balance of power by utilizing their political resources (e.g. electoral mandates, political capital, coalescence of pro-democracy coalitions) assertively so that officers are held in check should they decide to preserve or even expand prerogatives enjoyed under military rule. While bold steps are taken to accrue civilian power and establish legal precedent, smaller steps are also taken with respect to the other components of CMR during the transitional phase. Political leaders cannot afford to ignore other facets of CMR, but neither can they make concerted progress until the first two macros have been launched.

Then in democracy's consolidating phase, it becomes easier to strengthen defense institutions (dimension 3) and staff them with more knowledgeable civilians (dimension 4) because a power advantage and a legal basis have been established. In the latter, consolidated phase, the most challenging tasks – to change military and societal values (dimension 5) and to implement really effective defense policies (dimension 6) – can be tackled more aggressively. Values – particularly among indoctrinated soldiers – are often deeply rooted, and transforming them will take some time. Greater defense performance is achieved when skilled policymakers are in place. That process too will be largely deferred until a “defense establishment” is solidified from which highly trained civilian personnel can be drawn – all part of generating knowledge (dimension 4). Again, while efforts to address these can be initiated at any point in the process and often are, these are CMR dimensions that usually take a longer time to come into fruition. Thus, political leaders pursue CMR reforms with different levels of intensity through the three phases, depending upon which set of bundled relations one is referring to.⁵⁵

CMR REFORMATION AND ITS LINK TO DEMOCRATIZATION

As mentioned, the civil-military complex can be thought of as a subsystem within the larger democracy. While embedded, it has its own dynamic, as it moves through a sequence of steps en route toward the goal of democratically compatible military reform. As it evolves, so too does the political system as a whole. What is the relationship between changes in CMR and changes in the democracy writ large? And does one give impetus to the other? This can be thought of as a sequential process that traverses three iterations. In the first, it is the democratic proponents who initiate change, with the outgoing authoritarian leaders putting up the most resistance. Former rulers and their coalitional allies resist because they stand to lose the most. Their perks, privileges, and prerogatives could be stripped away under democratic rule. Thus initial reforms must be

⁵⁵ Narcís Serra (2010) suggests a sequencing of military reform efforts as well. Where we depart from Serra is in his contention that reforms can be sharply divided between those that are transitional in nature only and those that are strictly associated with consolidation. From the point of transition onward, reform efforts proceed on practically all fronts but at different levels of intensity and with different rates of success.

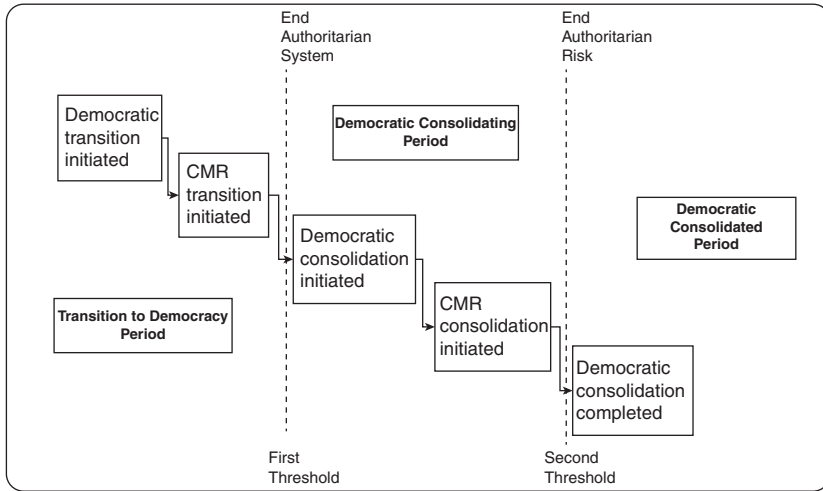


FIGURE 1.3 Sequencing of Democratic and Civil-Military Relations Reforms
Source: Authors

made first by democrats, who after having suffered extensive deprivations under authoritarian rule are only too eager to advance the cause of competition, civil liberties, and political rights. They focus first on these core components to a viable democracy before attending to CMR transformations.

Those reforms will stir incipient CMR transformations. As Larry Diamond and Marc F. Plattner stated, “If democracy works in other respects, it is likely over time to bring progress in civil-military relations as well.”⁵⁶ But while democrats can and do initiate the transition, they cannot complete it unless and until first-stage CMR reforms have advanced sufficiently.⁵⁷ Put differently, the system cannot cross the first threshold to acquire a democratic character until this one key component part – the CMR – has made concerted progress as well. At a minimum, that means that civilians have reduced military autonomy and decision-making latitude and have written new statutes designed to redefine the military’s roles in a democracy. That first iteration is displayed in Figure 1.3.

⁵⁶ Larry Diamond and Marc F. Plattner (eds.), *Civil-Military Relations and Democracy* (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1996), xxxiii.

⁵⁷ Brian Loveman and Thomas Davies Jr. (eds.), *The Politics of Antipolitics: The Military in Latin America* (Wilmington: SR Books, 1997), 393.

During the second iteration, a consolidating phase, a similar pattern will develop. The democratic system will continue to progress and, in doing so, give further encouragement to CMR reforms. To consolidate itself, the polity will have to accomplish, among other things, the goal of democratic deepening. Deepening is a process of making the democracy more liberal, representative, responsive, and accountable. Legislators and presidents are not the only ones who must be held accountable. It is, as Diamond explains, executive agencies – *military included* – that must answer “to the law, to other branches of government, and to the public” (emphasis ours).⁵⁸

If the military must answer to others for its conduct, it is civilian leaders who will or will not compel it to do so. Unless or until the armed forces have thoroughly internalized principles of subordination and acquired what Fitch referred to as a democratic professionalist mind-set, then self-monitoring and restraint are unlikely.⁵⁹ It will fall to others to call soldiers to task when they shirk their duties or otherwise display uncooperative behavior. And it will fall to civilian leaders not only to monitor and politically manage the military but to oversee the full range of defense and security-related programs. For this to occur, civilians will have to, in Stepan’s terms, “empower themselves to increase their own capacity for control.”⁶⁰ That returns us to dimension 4 and the subject of “generating knowledge.” It is by formulating educational career-tracked experiences that a cadre of young professionals will develop the necessary expertise to manage military issues within the offices of state. This takes time and is unlikely to emerge full bloom until democracy is consolidating (Table 1.3) and CMR’s own consolidation period is initiated (Figure 1.3) and beyond.

Consequently, it is those kinds of transformations that permit not only the CMR to evolve to the next level but the democracy as well. As Larry Diamond asserts, “By definition, democracy cannot be consolidated until the military becomes firmly subordinated to civilian control, and committed to the democratic constitutional order.”⁶¹ In the third iteration (Figure 1.3) the democracy crosses the next threshold into a phase of completion, when it has fully consolidated its gains. It is a phase marked

⁵⁸ Larry Diamond, *Developing Democracy: Toward Consolidation* (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1999), 75.

⁵⁹ Fitch, *The Armed Forces and Democracy*, 65–72.

⁶⁰ Stepan, *Rethinking Military Politics*, 144. ⁶¹ Diamond, *Developing Democracy*, 133.

by considerable stability and an end to the risk of backpedaling or, worse still, an authoritarian reversion.

CASE SELECTION

Argentina, Brazil, Chile, and Uruguay have been chosen for empirical investigation. Why these four Latin American countries? As members of the same subregion, they are geographically proximate. They share borders that once gave rise to geopolitical disputes sometimes verging on war. Those disputes also led to historic settlements, treaties, and a prolonged era of strategic peace and partnerships, all forged diplomatically. Those achievements are important because in reducing tensions between states, they also posed a common challenge: what motivations would there be to maintain proper defenses without the threat of foreign aggression? That reality would inevitably have to be factored in when contemplating how to achieve higher levels of effectiveness and how to repurpose militaries so they align with the foreign policies of peaceful, democratic states.

It might be said that this collection of states is not emblematic, since they do reside in a very low-risk environment, one that is not particularly conducive to the construction of effective defense systems. Lessons drawn from Southern Cone experiences would invariably differ from those drawn from states situated in higher-risk security zones. That is so, and one would not expect Argentina, Brazil, Chile, and Uruguay to be building the same kind of defense systems needed, say, in South Korea, Taiwan, India, or Israel. However, for purposes of this study, effectiveness is not about building the perfect war machine to confront hostile neighbors. It's about calibrating military forces to the needs of a particular country. It is about adjusting size, budgets, missions, and strategy so that they mesh with national priorities and government policy objectives. How precisely those adjustments will be made naturally varies from one nation to the next. But inevitably, all states need to make them.

Moreover, the choice of these four countries is, in some sense, a difficult test for military reform. Because these nations reside in an especially low-threat security environment where there is no realistic war scenario on the horizon, it is more difficult for their political leaders to focus attention on military and defense-related issues. In this more tranquil subregion, there is no sense of urgency propelling politicians to address problems in military recruitment, size, deployment, readiness, mission orientation,

education, and values. Likewise, on the civilian side of the equation, there is little pressure to make defense policy and planning a priority, to revamp defense ministries, or to employ skilled civilians able to fill staff positions within the defense sector. Reforms of these kinds could be deferred indefinitely without placing these nations in any peril. Accordingly, if political military reforms could be enacted in this subregion, they ought to be doable elsewhere.

Beyond geopolitics, all these nations emerged from periods of military-authoritarian rule born in the 1960s and 1970s, embarked upon regime transitions in the 1980s, and presently are considered to be some of the more consolidated democracies in Latin America.⁶² Economically, all of them are member states of MERCOSUR, which, at least at the outset, revealed complementary economic structures and aspirations. In sum, these four countries share similarities sufficient to justify an “apples to apples” comparison of their CMR reform efforts.

Holding constant for these historical and contextual factors, we can then assess some explanations for why CMR reform paths might have diverged. As we’ve argued, the different component parts of the CMR, bundled as dimensions, do not undergo change at the same time or pace. But it is equally plausible that countries do not advance at the same rate either. Each of these four countries confronts the same set of CMR challenges, but they have not done so with the same intensity or speed, meaning to date some have advanced further than others. What then might explain the differences across these four nations? Are there political forces, *independent of the CMR as defined*, that have either facilitated or impeded civil-military reformations? That inquiry will be deferred for the concluding chapter.

There may not be a singular template for all nations to follow. Barany is probably right that diverse settings make for generalizations that run the risk of incompatibility and triviality and render the search for a unified theory fruitless. And yet this did not stop him from generating policy recommendations for all based on the successes of a wide variety of states that have built democratic armies.⁶³ We have devised a framework with the conviction that insights that could be gleaned from its application to the four Latin American nations may be transportable elsewhere. Whether

⁶² The four countries were cataloged as “Free” by Freedom House in 2014. See Freedom House, *Freedom in the World*, 2014, <https://freedomhouse.org/sites/default/files/>.

⁶³ Barany, *The Soldier and the Changing State*, 342, 349–56.

the model could be successfully exported to other countries and regions cannot be known in advance; it can only be known through repeated efforts to apply it to other contexts.

CONCLUSION

The central question driving this research is when can it be said that the armed forces have been sufficiently transformed so that they faithfully serve the goals set out for them by a democratic state and society? They must be brought under control, but explanations must reach beyond that to assess multiple facets of the civil-military relation. This more holistic approach examines the interactions the military engage in with its parent society and with institutions of state by first disaggregating these into six sets of bundled relations called dimensions, each with its own components. Progress to date in reforming each component of the CMR is then assessed and ordinal values are assigned. It is surmised that considerable progress in each of the six dimensions is necessary if the armed forces are to become fully integrated into the democracy.

Incremental reforms to each component are then situated within phases of transition and a two-staged consolidation. The CMR itself traverses across thresholds, moving from one period to the next, as it advances toward the goal of a democratically compliant and compatible military. Within each phase, reform efforts are under way. Policymakers are not locked into an inflexible formula or schedule and can tackle problems along multiple fronts simultaneously. By the same token, some problems are more pressing than others and demand immediate attention, while others can be addressed later on. For this reason, each period will witness issues that are addressed with different levels of intensity.

CMR is but one component of a democracy, but a vital one. Neither it nor the larger system of which it is a part can make significant headway without help from the other. In essence, democratic changes nudge CMR reforms along, while an improved CMR makes further democratic progress possible.